UNIVERSAL CIVILITY

It had been seven years since the royal ladies' hajj party had been gone from Fatehpur Sikri so when they returned to the capital in April 1582, they were greeted with exuberant and resplendent joy. Gulbadan and her party had decided to stop en route at Muinuddin Chishti's dargah for a final thanksgiving and Salim, favourite of the harem, was sent to Ajmer to formally welcome the ladies back to Hindustan. Every day after that a different nobleman of rank was sent to salute the women as they made their way back to Fatehpur Sikri and when they reached Bharatpur, Akbar himself rode out to meet his aunt. The Padshah had had the pavements in Fatehpur Sikri covered with silken shawls and he 'conducted her himself to her palace in a gorgeous litter, scattering largesse meanwhile to the crowds'. As Gulbadan, Salima Sultan, and the other women settled back into the harem, after their many years away, they would hear from Hamida Banu and the other ladies of some truly intriguing changes at court. Perhaps the most provocative of the new visitors they were told about were the Jesuits, for from this time on, after the return of Gulbadan, the priests began to feel decidedly unwelcome at the Mughal court.

The Mughal harem had always shown a great solidarity in the causes they supported from the time of Babur, whether it was protecting the interests of a favoured prince or undermining the power of a disruptive regent or arranging marriages. In their distaste for the Jesuits and the Portuguese, the harem appeared to have been united once again and it was evident enough to have been recorded by a foreign traveller, Thomas Coryat, an Englishman at the court of Jahangir. '[Akbar] never denyed [his mother] anything but this,' said Thomas Coryat, 'that shee demanded of him that our Bible might be hanged about an asses necke and beaten about the towne of Agra, for that the Portugals…tied (the Quran) about the necke of a dogge and beat the same dog about the towne of Ormuz.' Hamida Banu's fury at the Portuguese's disrespect of the Koran was understandable but this once, Akbar refused to do as she suggested for 'the contempt of any religion was the contempt of God'.